

Session 22: God Wrestles With Jacob

Key Takeaways

- The letters of Yaaqov's name are littered throughout the narrative where his name is changed.
- The judgment that Yaaqov faces, being wounded in his striving against God, comes to its ultimate fulfillment in the suffering of the Messiah on our behalf.
- The biblical authors depict the true-to-life experience of the tension between God's sovereignty and human free will, but they do not attempt to resolve the tension for us.

God Wrestles With Yaaqov

22 And **he arose** (ויקם) **in the night** ,
and he took his two wives and his two female slaves and his eleven children
and he **crossed** (יעבר) the **Yabbok** (יבק) .

23 **And he took** them
and he made them **cross** (יעבר) the stream,
and he made **cross** (יעבר) all that belonged to him.

24 And **Yaaqov** (יעקב) was left alone

and a **man** (איש) **wrestled** (יאבק) with him until the **rising of dawn** (עלות השחר).

25 And he saw that he could not **prevail** (יכול) him
and he touched (ויגע) **the hollow of his thigh** (כף ירכו)
and it was **jerked away** (יקע) , **the hollow of his thigh** (כף ירך) of **Yaaqov** (יעקב)
as he **wrestled** (בהאבקו) with him.

26 And he said,
"Send me away,
for (כי) **the sun has gone up** (עלה השחר) !"

And he said,
"I will not send you away,
unless (כי אם) you **bless** (ברך) me!"

27 And he said to him, "What is **your name** (מה) + (שמך)?"

And he said, " **Yaaqov** (יעקב) ."

28 And he said,
"Not **Yaaqov** (יעקב) will **your name** (שם) be spoken any more,

rather (כי אם) **Yisrael** (ישראל)
for (כי) you have struggled/ruled (שרה) with **God and humans** (אלהים) + (איש),
 and you have **prevailed** (יכול)."

²⁹ And **Yaaqov** requested, "Tell me, please, **your name**!" (שם)

And he said, "Why (למה) do you request **my name** (שם)?"

And he **blessed** (ברך) him there (שם).

³⁰ And Yaaqov called **the name** (שם) of the place **Peniel**,

for (כי) "I have seen **God face** to **face** and my life was delivered."

³¹ And **the sun rose** (ויזרח השמש),

as he **crossed** (עבר) at **Penuel**,

and he limped (צלע) on **his thigh** (ירכו).

³² Therefore, the sons of Israel do not eat **the sinew of the hip-nerve** (גיד הנשה)

which is on **the hollow of the thigh** (כף ירך) to this very day,

for (כי) he touched (נגע) **the hollow of the thigh** (כף ירך) of **Yaaqov** (יעקב) by **the sinew of the hip-nerve** (גיד הנשה).

Genesis 32:22-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

In the translation above, the pervasive wordplays on the letters of Yaaqov's name are displayed in red font. The narrative revolves around the change of Yaaqov's name to Yisrael, and the focus on his name is embedded into the very wording of the story itself.

Yaaqov Wrestles With Elohim, Esau, and Lavan

There is a deliberate analogy drawn between Yaaqov's meeting and confrontation with Lavan in chapter 31 and his confrontation and meeting with Esau in chapters 32-33. Both units consist of seven clearly marked scenes, and they match verbally and thematically. [Adapted from Gordon Wenham, [Genesis 16-50](#), p. 287-88]

	Genesis 31 Yaaqov and Lavan	Genesis 32-33: Yaaqov and Esau
Scene 1	Gen. 31:1-3 Instructions to leave	Gen. 32:3-6 Planning to meet Esau
Scene 2	Gen. 31:4-18 Preparations to leave "He lifted up his sons, and his wives upon camels ... and his flock (מקנה) and all his possessions which he possessed, flock and possessions"	Gen. 32:7-21 Preparations to meet Esau "And he took ... an offering (מנחה) for Esau: she-goats, he-goats, sheep, rams, camels, cows, bulls, she-donkeys, he-donkeys."
Scene 3	Gen. 31:17-21 Departure and crossing of Euphrates	Gen. 32:22-23 Crossing of Yabbok

Yaaqov Wrestles Elohim, Esau, and Lavan. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Genesis 31 Yaaqov and Lavan		Genesis 32-33: Yaaqov and Esau
	"And he arose (וַיָּקָם) and he took his sons, and his wives ... and he fled and all who were with him (וְכָל אֲשֶׁר לוֹ), and he crossed (וַיַּעְבֵּר) the river and he set his face (פָּנָיו) to Mount Gilead."	"And he arose (וַיָּקָם) and he took his two wives and two maidservants and his eleven sons, and he crossed (וַיַּעְבֵּר) the crossing of the Yabbok. ... and he made all who were with him (אֶת אֲשֶׁר לוֹ) cross."
Scene 4	Gen. 31:22-24 Pursuit by Lavan Gen. 31:23 "and he clung (וַיִּדְבֶּק) to him"	Gen. 32:24-32 Struggle with the man Gen. 32:24 "and he struggled (וַיִּאָבֵק) with him"
Scene 5	Gen. 31:25-54 Confrontation with Lavan	Gen. 33:1-15 Confrontation with Esau
Scene 6	Gen. 31:55-32:1a Parting of Lavan and Yaaqov "And Lavan went and returned (וַיָּלֶךְ וַיָּשָׁב) to his place, and Yaaqov went to his path (לְדַרְכּוֹ)."	Gen. 33:16-17 Parting of Esau and Yaaqov "and Esau returned (וַיָּשָׁב) to his path (לְדַרְכּוֹ) ... and Yaaqov went (וַיָּבֹא) to Sukkoth."
Scene 7	Gen. 32:1-2 Conclusion/Preview Yaaqov comes to the camp of Elohim	Gen. 33:18-20 Conclusion/Preview Yaaqov camped by the city
Yaaqov Wrestles Elohim, Esau, and Lavan. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

At the center of these two stories is the struggle of Yaaqov with the "man" in the nighttime, and Yaaqov's renaming, which revolves around his "wrestling with God and with men (i.e., Lavan and Esau) and you overcame (וַתִּגְבַּל)" ((Gen. 32:29).

This nighttime story becomes a thematic parable of the entire Yaaqov cycle: His struggle with humans to gain a blessing for himself parallels his struggle with God to create his own blessing. This theme is also an image of the Genesis scroll's entire plot conflict about humanity's attempt to create its own Eden blessing after being expelled from the garden.

"The night attack, the life and death struggle, and finally the unexpected conclusion, the gracious blessing and bestowal of a new name, that is ... God's answer to the deceiver Jacob ... whereby God's sovereignty and faithfulness to his promise despite all human unworthiness is demonstrated. Jacob is no longer the strong victorious controller of the divine but Israel who is totally dependent on God's grace, and now lame."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1998). [Genesis 16–50, vol. 2](#). Word Biblical Commentary. Dallas: Word, Incorporated. 294.

God Picks a Fight and Wounds His Chosen One

The identity of the man (Heb. אִישׁ) is left for the reader to ponder in light of narratives elsewhere in the Genesis scroll and in light of other details within this story.

- When Yahweh appeared to Abraham by his tent in Mamre, it was in the form of a man (אִישׁ, see [Gen. 18:1-3](#)).
- Another mysterious man (אִישׁ) will guide Joseph to his brothers ([Gen. 37:15](#)), which Joseph later sees as an expression of divine guidance (“God sent me here,” [Gen. 45:5](#)).
- The man who wrestles with Yaaqov can offer Yahweh’s blessing ([32:29](#)).
- Yaaqov describes the experience as “seeing *Elohim* face to face!” (see [32:30](#)).

The fact that the man is Yahweh in human form only makes the story more puzzling.

- How is it that God cannot “prevail” over Yaaqov?
- And why would God have to strike Yaaqov in the crotch to wound him?

These details of the story are an intentional riddle meant to offer a commentary on the surrounding stories.

God Wrestles With Yaaqov

God spoke a word of blessing and choice over Yaaqov before he was born. And yet, from his first moments, Yaaqov has been seizing for the position of the firstborn blessing. This “heel grabbing” continued in Rivqah and Yaaqov's deception, in Yaaqov's deception of Lavan, and now in his attempt to bribe forgiveness from Esau.

At each point, God allows Yaaqov's deceit to turn back upon him, bringing more pain and isolation. And yet Yaaqov never seems to learn. He just repeats his old ways.

And so God gets personally involved and wounds Yaaqov so thoroughly he cannot recover.

This story is a vivid image of God’s journey with humanity as a whole and with his chosen people in particular. God’s purpose is to bless, and that purpose keeps bumping up against humanity’s inability to trust God’s generous intentions. Instead, Yaaqov keeps scheming as if the ultimate blessing is up to him.

Why a Strike to the Crotch?

When Abraham was concerned about the future of his family, he made his servant swear an oath by “placing your hand under my thigh (תחת ירכי, see [Gen. 24:2](#).) This is precisely the region of Yaaqov's crotch struck by the divine man. It’s a strike to the reproductive region, and while Benjamin is yet to be born (see [Gen. 35](#)), it’s not impossible that Rakhel is already pregnant.

God responded to Abraham and Sarah's sin against Hagar with judgement and mercy through circumcision. In a similar way, God responds harshly by wounding Yaaqov in the same area. Yaaqov will walk with a limp, forever wounded.

Suffering: The Way to Blessing

Both of these details point in the same direction: God's ultimate desire is to partner with humans, who are currently represented by the family of Abraham. But what if his chosen people are so recalcitrant that they continually become a source of curse among the nations instead of being a blessing? God reaches a point where the only option is to wound his chosen one, striking him in order to make him an able conduit of blessing to others.

This story seems to echo the equally dense riddle spoken by Yahweh to the snake in Genesis 3:15.

Genesis 3:15 Instructor's Translation

And I will set hostility between you and the woman,
and between your seed and her seed;
he will strike your head,
and you will strike his heel.

Yaaqov was born "grabbing the heel" of his brother, which began a cascade of painful consequences that eventually come back on Yaaqov's head. It's as if his own failures become the way his own heel is struck in return.

Yaaqov suffers as a result of his own sin against others, and this, it appears, is the way that God's purpose to bless comes about (see [Gen. 50:20](#))!

From Yaaqov to Israel

The name change is hugely significant. The meaning of Yaaqov's entire life up to this point is packed into this little narrative and into this new name.

- Yaaqov = "heel-er," i.e., "heel-grabber, trickster"
- Yisrael = "he struggles with El"

"Names throughout Scripture are significant, but changes of name in midlife are specially so (cf. Abram/Abraham and Sarai/Sarah in [17:5](#), [15](#)). Here Jacob's new name was to become the nation's name, and it is fraught with significance. Israel, 'God fights or rules,' is here reinterpreted as a reference to Jacob's struggle with God. Yet this reinterpretation captures the paradox of Jacob's struggle precisely. For while Jacob struggled with God, it was God who allowed Jacob to triumph in the fight ... Jacob's experience at the Yabbok, wrestling with God and yet surviving, was in later times seen as prefiguring the national experience ([Hos. 12:5](#)). Running through the psalms of national lament there is a similar conviction that the nation's trials are heaven-sent; yet only from heaven can they look for deliverance (e.g., [Ps. 74](#), [79](#), [80](#), [83](#)). So this story of Jacob's struggle with God summed up for Israel their national destiny. Among all their trials and perplexities in which God seemed to be fighting against them, he was ultimately on their side; indeed, he would triumph, and in his victory, Israel would triumph too ..."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1998). [Genesis 16–50, vol. 2](#). Word Biblical Commentary. Dallas: Word, Incorporated. 302-303.

Links With Earlier Narrative Patterns in the Genesis Scroll

Genesis 32-33 and the Eden Narrative

The entire sequence of [Genesis 32-33](#) is overlaid with verbal references back to the core patterns of Genesis 1-11.

Yaaqov's Nighttime Meeting With Yahweh	Adam's Nighttime Meeting With Yahweh
Gen. 32:22 And [Yaaqov] arose on that night	Gen. 2:21a And Yahweh caused a deep sleep to fall upon the human
Gen. 32:24 And Yaaqov was left alone (לבדו)	Gen. 2:18 And Yahweh God said, "Not good is the human being alone (לבדו)"
Gen. 32:25 And [the divine man] saw that he could not overcome him, and he touched the socket of his thigh (ירכו) Gen. 32:31 ... and [Yaaqov] limped (צלע) upon his thigh	Gen. 2:21b-22 and [Yahweh] took one from his sides (צלע) ... And Yahweh built the side (צלע) into a woman
Yaaqov Eden Narrative Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Both narratives portray a lone human who is unable to fulfill the purpose of God by themselves. So God comes in a mysterious, vivid way and performs a surprise "procedure" that opens up the pathway to divine blessing. In both stories, the character transitions from a place of inability and moves into a place of divine enablement.

- In the human's case, the one is divided into two, opening up the possibility for the two to become one and produce many descendants.
- In Yaaqov's case, the one is struck in his reproductive organs, seeming closing off the possibility for future descendants. But this humiliating and wounding experience is what shifts Yaaqov into a new mindset, displayed in the next story.

Genesis 32-33 and the Cain and Abel Narrative

Yaaqov and Esau	Cain and Abel
Gen. 33:10 "Please now, if I find favor in your eyes, then you will take my offering (מנחה) from my hand ..."	Gen. 4:3-6 Two brothers bring an offering (מנחה), one is favored and one is not, resulting in anger and sibling rivalry
Yaaqov and Cain & Abel Narrative Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Yaaqov and Esau

Cain and Abel

Gen. 32:12 “And you said, ‘I will surely do good (היטב איטיב) to you and make your seed like the sand of the sea.’”

Gen. 4:7 “If you do good (תיטיב) there will be exaltation; and if you don’t do good (לא תיטיב) ...”

Gen. 32:11 “Deliver me from the hand of my brother, Esau ... so that he doesn’t come and strike me.”

Gen. 4:8 “And while they were in the field, Cain rose up against his brother and he murdered him.”

Yaaqov and Cain & Abel Narrative Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The sibling rivalry theme of Cain and Abel has reached its culmination in the Yaaqov and Esau story. It deliberately comes to its resolution by activating the vocabulary of the story from [Genesis 4](#). However, instead of the older brother murdering the younger, Esau is surprisingly generous and forgives.

Genesis 32-33 and the Flood Narrative

Genesis 6:7, 13 NASB

⁷ And Yahweh said, “I will wipe away humanity that I created from the face of the ground, from humanity to animals to creeping things and to birds of the skies, for I consoled myself (נחם) that I have made them” ...

¹³ And *Elohim* said to Noah, “The end (קץ) of all flesh has come before me, because the land is filled with violence because of them, and behold, I am going to ruin them with land.”

Genesis 8:21 NASB

And Yahweh smelled the soothing smell; and Yahweh said to his heart (לבו), “I will never again curse the ground on account of humanity, because the purpose of the heart of humanity is bad from his youth; and I will never again strike all life, as I just did.”

Genesis 27

Genesis 32-33

Genesis 6-8

Gen. 27:41 “And Esau held a grudge against Yaaqov ... and **he said in his heart** (אמר + בלבו), ‘The days of mourning (אבל / הבל) are near, and I will **murder Yaaqov my brother** (הרג + אחי)’”

Gen. 32:7 “And Yaaqov was greatly afraid, **and distress** (ויצר) was to him.”

Gen. 6:5 “And Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land, and every **purpose** (יצר) of the plans of **his heart** (לבו) was only bad all the day.”

Yaaqov Flood Narrative Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Genesis 27	Genesis 32-33	Genesis 6-8
Gen. 27:42 "Behold, Esau your brother is consoling himself (נחם) regarding you, to murder you (הרג)"		Gen. 6:6 "And Yahweh consoled himself (נחם) that he made humanity in the land, and he was pained in his heart (לבו)."
	Gen. 32:5 "I have sent to my lord, to find favor in your eyes (למצא חן בעיניך)"	Gen. 6:8 "But Noah found favor (מצא חן) in the eyes of Yahweh"
	Gen. 32:8 "and if he strikes it (Hiph. נכה) then there will be the camp that remains (נשאר) as one who escapes (פליטה)."	The flood is God's "strike (נכה) on all life" (8:21), but only Noah and family "remains" (ישאר, 7:23)
	Gen. 32:16 "And he said to his servants, 'Cross over before me, and place a space of rest (רוח) between flock and between flock"	Gen. 8:1, 4 God sends out a "breath/wind" (רוח) over the waters which recede so the ark can "rest" (נוח) on the mountain
	Gen. 32:17-20 "And he commanded the first (הראשון) ... and he commanded the second (השני) and also the third (השלישי) ... for he said, ' I will cover his face (כפר) with the offering (מנחה).'" Gen. 33:2 "And he set (וישם) the maidservants and children first (ראשנה), and Leah and her children afterwards (אחרנים), and Rakhel and Joseph afterwards (אחרנים)."	Gen. 6:14-16 "Make for yourself an ark of gopher wood ... you will make it with lowers (תחתיות) , seconds (שנים), and thirds (שלשים)."
Gen. 27:27 "[Yitskhaq] smelled the aroma (וירח ריח) of [Yaaqov's] garments, he blessed	Gen. 33:10 "If I may find favor in your eyes (מצאתי חן בעיניך), then take my offering (מנחה) from	Gen. 8:21 "Yahweh smelled the soothing aroma (וירח יהוה את ריח) and said in his

Genesis 27	Genesis 32-33	Genesis 6-8
him, 'The smell (ריח) of my son ...'"	my hand, for on account of seeing your face as one sees the face of God, then you will accept me favorably (ותרצני)."	heart, 'I will never again curse the ground ...'"
	Word plays on "Noah" (נוח) • "camp" (מחנה) • "offering" (מנחה) • "favor" (חן) • "show favor" (חנן)	Word-plays on "Noah" (נוח) • "rest" (נוח) • "smell a restful smell" (ריח ניחוח) • "favor" (חן)
Yaaqov Flood Narrative Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

In each case, Yaaqov plays the opposite role of Noah, who received divine favor as a gift and built the ark in response to the divine command. Contrast Noah with Yaaqov, who builds his own scheme of blessing and salvation from Esau and keeps trying to engineer his own "favor" (חן) in the eyes of "my lord" (Esau/God, as [Gen. 32:29](#) makes clear).

Yaaqov's three-part division of the people and animals looks conspicuously like the three-part division of the ark's stories.

Notes on flood analogies: Esau coming with anger and wrath is set on analogy with God in the flood, but ironically Esau, it turns out, is not angry. Yaaqov believes that Esau, like God in the flood, is coming to "strike" ([Gen. 32:9](#)), and so he needs to be sent an "offering" ([Gen. 32:14, 19](#); מנחה) in order "that I might appease his face" (אכפרה פניו, [32:21](#)). However, Esau needs no such persuading, and he will gladly receive his humbled brother with joy.

Reflection Question

How does Yaaqov's wrestling with God further develop the portrait of God's chosen one?